morning.

I was speeding down Route 32 under a beautiful Microsoft-blue sky, trying not to get caught by any speed traps. With a little luck, I'd roll into Mae's sometime before 9:30, and—with my window down and my hand riding the wind—it felt like a lucky day. I had the talk radio cranked and was waiting for the news to switch to the traffic.

Just as I was about to take the Canine Road shortcut into Fort Meade, an update broke through about a plane crash in New York City.

Mae came to the door and I followed her up the stairs from the dim entryway to the cramped office next to her bedroom. There wasn't much to it: just our two desks side by side, a drawing table for her art, and a cage for her squirrels. Though I was slightly distracted by the news, we had work to do. I forced myself to focus on the task at hand. I was just opening the project's files in a simple text editor—we wrote the code for websites by hand—when the phone rang.

Mae picked up. "What? Really?"

Because we were sitting so close together, I could hear her husband's voice. And he was yelling.

Mae's expression turned to alarm, and she loaded a news site on her computer. The only TV was downstairs. I was reading the site's report about a plane hitting one of the Twin Towers of the World Trade Center, when Mae said, "Okay. Wow. Okay," and hung up.

She turned to me. "A second plane just hit the other tower."

Until that moment, I'd thought it had been an accident.

Mae said, "Norm thinks they're going to close the base."

"Like, the gates?" I said. "Seriously?" The scale of what had happened had yet to hit me. I was thinking about my commute.

"Norm said you should go home. He doesn't want you to get stuck."

I sighed, and saved the work I'd barely started. Just when I got up to leave, the phone rang again, and this time the conversation was even shorter. Mae was pale.

"You're not going to believe this."

Pandemonium, chaos: our most ancient forms of terror. They both refer to a collapse of order and the panic that rushes in to fill the void. For as long as I live, I'll remember retracing my way up Canine Road—the road past the NSA's headquarters—after the Pentagon was attacked. Madness poured out of the agency's black glass towers, a tide of yelling, ringing cell phones, and cars revving up in the parking lots and fighting their way onto the street. At the